

1992 Oil production starts.

2004 Foreign mercenaries are arrested in suspected coup plot.

2006 Government resigns en masse following allegations of corruption.

2008 British mercenary Simon Mann extradited to Equatorial Guinea to face charges relating to 2004 coup attempt. He is sentenced to 34 years in prison but released in 2009.

«182–83 South of the Sahara

São Tomé & Príncipe



Two islands in the Gulf of Guinea that were controlled by Portugal for more than 500 years.

1470 Portuguese reach uninhabited islands and import African slaves to work on sugar and cocoa plantations.

1975 Independence as a Marxist one-party state; plantations nationalized.

1990 New democratic constitution introduces multi-party democracy.

1995 Príncipe is granted autonomy.

2001 Fradique de Menezes wins the presidency and promises greater cooperation with parliament. He survives an attempted coup in 2003.

2010 Opposition Independent Action Party (ADI) wins parliamentary elections.

«280–81 The Slave Trade

Gabon



An equatorial country that has made the post-colonial transition to multi-party democracy.

1472 Portuguese trading ships make the first European contact.

1600s European merchants trade tobacco, cloth, and arms for ivory, slaves, and rubber. The Fang, moving south from the savannah lands of Cameroon, expel the indigenous peoples.

1849 Libreville is founded by Vili slaves freed by the French.

1880 Count Savorgnan de Brazza signs a treaty with King Makoko of the Teke that gives France rights over a vast tract of central Africa, although most of this area was not under the control of Makoko.

1960 Independence from France: Léon M'ba is president.

1964 Military coup. French intervene to reinstate M'ba.

1967 Albert-Bernard (later Omar) Bongo becomes president.

1968 Single-party state instituted.

1990 Multi-party democracy.

2006 Gabon enters talks with Equatorial Guinea over disputed oil-rich waters.

2009 Omar Bongo dies after 42 years as president. His son Ali Ben Bongo wins presidential election amidst allegations of fraud.

«280–81 The Slave Trade

Central African Rep



A landlocked, unstable country that has been plagued by military coups and rebel insurgencies.

1500s Slave raids from the north and west are common.

1800s Baya arrive from Cameroon, fleeing the Fulani; later in the century, the Banda flee Islamic slavers in Sudan.

1889 French establish a base at Bangui.

1905 Oubangui-Chari territory is united with Chad. Later revolts by the plantation forced-labor workers are suppressed.

1950 First parliamentary deputy, Barthélemy Boganda, founds Movement for Social Evolution in Black Africa.

1958 Internal self-government is granted with Boganda as prime minister.

1960 Independence under David Dacko (Boganda having died in a plane crash).

1966 Coup by Jean-Bédél Bokassa, who in 1977 proclaims himself emperor.



Emperor Bokassa I

Dictator of the Central African Republic from 1966, Jean-Bédél Bokassa (1921–96) crowned himself emperor in 1977. He was overthrown in 1979 and put on trial for the brutal excesses of his regime.

1979 French help overthrow Bokassa and reinstate Dacko.

1981 General Kolingba ousts Dacko.

1996 Government of national unity formed following army rebellion; further coups continue to destabilize the country.

2005 Thousands flee lawless north into neighboring Chad.

2007 Rebel leaders sign a peace accord with President Bozize in Libya.

2008 Two of three main rebel groups sign a peace accord with the government.

2009 A national unity government is formed, including former rebels.

Congo



An oil- and timber-rich country appallingly governed in the years since independence.

1400s Two kingdoms occupy present-day Congo: Loango in the south, Makoko farther inland; the northern forest regions are the home of Binga pygmies.

1880 French explorer Count Savorgnan de Brazza visits the region. He establishes a treaty with Makoko, chief of Teke, which he claims gives rights to the region.

1891 Congo is founded on the north bank of Stanley Pool on the Zaire River.

1910 French Congo is integrated into French Equatorial Africa.

1940 The French governor, Félix Éboué, supports de Gaulle and rejects France's Vichy government.

1944 De Gaulle holds conference in Brazzaville to reorganize African colonies.

1956 Abbé Fulbert Youlou founds the Democratic Union for the Defense of African Interests (UDDIA).

1958 Admission of Congo to Franco-African Community as an autonomous state.

1960 Independence from France as Republic of Congo.

1968–91 Declared a one-party Marxist–Leninist state.

1992–97 Political violence, coups, and rebellions weaken the country.

1997–2003 Violence erupts when the president tries to disarm militias ahead of elections; a peace deal with Ninja rebel militia eventually brings some stability.

2009 President Dennis Ngess is elected for second term in elections boycotted by the opposition.

«412–13 End of the Colonial Era

Dem Rep Congo



Africa's third-largest country, bankrupted since independence by its long-serving dictator.

1400s Kongo emerges as a powerful kingdom on the coast.

1885 King Leopold of Belgium's claim to the Congo as his personal fiefdom is recognized at the Berlin Conference.

1908 Belgium takes over Congo Free State from Leopold.

1957 Limited African rule introduced.

1960 Independence of Republic of Congo with Patrice Lumumba as prime minister. Katanga (Shaba) secedes; Belgian troops are sent in; Lumumba is arrested.

1961 Lumumba is murdered. In 2002, the Belgian government admits that it killed him and apologizes.

1963 Katanga secession collapses.

1965 Joseph Désiré Mobutu seizes power and starts stealing the country's wealth.

1970 Mobutu elected president; his Popular Revolutionary Movement (MPR) becomes sole legal party.

1971 Country is renamed Zaire.

1982 Opposition parties set up Union for Democracy and Social Progress (UDPS).

1990 Mobutu announces transition to multi-party rule after security forces kill prodemocracy demonstrators.

1996 Major insurgency launched in east by Alliance of Democratic Forces for the Liberation of the Congo (AFDL).

1997 Forces led by Laurent Kabila sweep south and west. Mobutu flees and dies in exile. The country is renamed the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

2000 UN approves peacekeeping mission; arrival stalled by Kabila, who is assassinated in 2001.

2006 Serious unrest as opposition rejects the victory in presidential elections of Laurent Kabila's son, Joseph.

2006 Forces of renegade general Laurent Nkunda and government troops clash in North Kivu province.

2008 Peace agreement is signed between government and Nkunda's rebel forces.

2008 Heavy clashes erupt in the east of the country between Rwandan Hutu militia and General Nkunda's forces.

2009 Government offensive defeats Nkunda, who is arrested in Rwanda.

«412–13 End of the Colonial Era